



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Ascent Colorado Classical Schools of Northern Colorado
School Website: <https://nc.ascentcolorado.org/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Ascent Classical Academy – Northern Colorado (ACANC) demonstrates a strong alignment with classical education across the six core categories. The public materials emphasize virtue, truth, and beauty; a forms-based, content-rich curriculum; and a traditional, teacher-led classroom culture. Great Books/Great Conversation and Grammar-Logic-Rhetoric cadences appear in the public materials, and the school explicitly situates education within moral formation, civic virtue, and the Western intellectual tradition. The most pronounced strengths lie in Curriculum, Pedagogy (as evidenced by lower- and upper-school practices), Faculty presence (visible teacher roles and a mission-driven staff), and Parents & Community partnerships (parent information sessions, tours, and engagement opportunities). Element 1 (Religious and Metaphysical Foundations) shows clear classical traits but lacks explicit theological or liturgical framing in the public materials, which places it as SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than fully CLASSICAL. Overall, the aggregate assessment for ACANC is CLASSICAL, with Element 1 being the primary axis where deeper explicit religious/theological articulation could further strengthen the classification.

Executive impressions by category (category-by-category snapshot below) indicate a school that consistently pursues classical aims of virtue, wisdom, and beauty through a content-rich liberal-arts curriculum and disciplined pedagogy, while still leaving room to more explicitly foreground theology or liturgical practice as part of the metaphysical foundations.

- Overall classification: CLASSICAL
- Notable needle-movers (if category 1 is strengthened): More explicit articulation of theology, liturgical community practices, and liturgical/theological integration across disciplines.

This evaluation relies on the school-public materials present in ACANC's Northern Colorado crawl content and the classical-school rubric and keyword lexicon from the knowledge base, including the Six Essential Elements of a Classical School (1) document.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The materials foreground transcendental aims such as truth, goodness, and beauty, and emphasize moral character and civic virtue as core aims of education. For example, public statements describe cultivating curiosity and wonder while pursuing truth, goodness, and beauty, and highlight moral formation as central to the educational mission. The school motto and pledge emphasize the true, the good, and the beautiful, tying education to moral ends. - The school's mission and vision frame education within a Western-traditional, virtue-oriented context, including statements about a republic and culturally rooted citizen formation. A visible emphasis on virtue and character aligns with transcendental realism in classical education. - There is strong emphasis on moral character and civic virtue as essential outcomes of the educational process.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: truth, goodness, beauty, virtue, moral character, civic virtue, wonder, Western tradition, true/good/beautiful (pursuit of the true, the good, and the beautiful), moral formation. - Negative keywords present: Few explicit references to liturgical or doctrinal-theological practices; no clear references to liturgy, worship, or formal theological integration in public-facing materials.

Why this rating - The materials clearly articulate transcendental aims and the formation of virtue and character (positive markers). However, explicit theological grounding, liturgical practices, or overt metaphysical-theology framing is not consistently evident in the public-facing content, limiting it from being classified as fully CLASSICAL in this category. The alignment is strong but not fully saturated with theological grounding as per the rubric.

Cited pointers - "Our heart is to cultivate our student's natural curiosity and wonder, help them to recognize their state of ignorance, and inspire them to pursue truth, goodness, and beauty." - Vision/Motto emphasizing moral ends and the Western tradition (motto: *Ad Maiora Ex Tenebris*; "Out of the darkness towards the greater things") and the focus on virtue and civic virtue. - Purposes of Classical Education describing virtue-oriented aims and civil conversation within a traditional context.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school explicitly states that the goal of education is the cultivation of virtue and wisdom, not job preparation; education is formation rather than information, aiming at human excellence and the love of the true, good, and beautiful. This is foregrounded in the "Purposes of Classical Education" and related content. - The mission emphasizes forming knowledgeable, virtuous citizens through a liberal-arts education, underscoring formation over mere data or job-skills outcomes. - The school emphasizes a content-rich, historically rooted education to sustain meaningful conversation about truth, beauty, and the good, rather than mere test-driven preparation.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: virtue, wisdom, formation, human excellence, truth, goodness, beauty, formation of character, civil conversation, liberal education, historically-rooted citizens. - Negative keywords present: none that directly imply anti-formation or job-centrism; the materials explicitly de-emphasize narrow test-focused goals, which aligns with formation emphasis.

Why this rating - The materials strongly emphasize virtue-, wisdom-, and character-centered aims and explicitly describe formation over job preparation, aligning with classical aims for Purpose and Goal. The absence of competing, non-formation goals in the public materials supports CLASSICAL in this category.

Cited pointers - "The goal of education is the cultivation of virtue and wisdom rather than preparation for work." - "Education is formation rather than information, that education should cultivate humanity or human excellence." - "A republic is best served when its citizens can formulate historically-rooted opinions, draw upon powerful myths, stories, allegories, and tales ..." and "the best kind of conversation" (truth, beauty, good).

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The curriculum is described as liberal-arts oriented (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and content-rich, with a strong emphasis on Great Books, history across curriculum, and engagement with the Great Conversation. The site describes reading whole books in depth and engaging with historical, literary, and scientific content. - Explicit reference to studying history throughout the curriculum, not merely as "social studies," and to a deep engagement with literature and the Western canon. - The Kindergarten curriculum map shows a structured approach to literacy, poetry, narration, and memorization; upper- and lower-school curricula include literature, history/geography, mathematics, sciences, and foreign language elements aligned with a

liberal-arts sequence. - The site mentions a Senior Thesis in the Upper School and a traditional liberal-arts sequence in the grammar/upper-school structure.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: liberal arts, grammar, logic, rhetoric, Great Books, Great Conversation, history, literature, science, mathematics, foreign language, Senior Thesis. - Negative keywords present: None indicating a departure from liberal-arts canon or Great Books approach; no strong anti-grammar/logic/rhetoric framing.

Why this rating - The explicit attention to liberal-arts roots (grammar-logic-rhetoric), Great Books engagement, and cross-disciplinary history-and-literature integration strongly supports CLASSICAL in Curriculum.

Cited pointers - “A Content-Rich Curriculum” and emphasis on reading whole books in depth, Great Books, and history across subjects. - Kindergarten curriculum map showing grammar-based literacy, narration, poetry, and recitation as foundational practices. - Senior Thesis as culmination in Upper School.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The site describes a traditional classroom where the teacher’s authority is central and students are active participants in discussion, suggesting a pedagogy that blends rigor with order and engagement. This aligns with classical pedagogy’s emphasis on dialogue in upper grades and a structured, memory-rich approach in younger grades. - Lower-school practices emphasize memory-building and recitation (poetry exposure, narration, recitation, etc.), while upper-school pedagogy includes discussion and civil discourse (implied Socratic-style dialogue and rigorous conversations). Kindergarten curriculum explicitly includes narration and recitation; upper grades emphasize literature, history, and rhetoric, with opportunities for presentations and thesis work. - The presence of a voluntary emphasis on disciplined dialogue and meaningful discussion aligns with the Socratic/seminar-driven tradition in high school years (as described in the classical framework).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Socratic dialogue (implied via civil discourse and deliberative discussion), dialectic, great conversation, guided discussion, rhetoric, recitation, memory work, scholé (restful, contemplative learning), wonder-based education, lectures and seminars in a structured classroom, long-form writing and senior thesis. - Negative keywords present: None indicating a purely test-driven, didactic approach; the emphasis remains balanced between rigorous discussion and contemplative, memory-based activities.

Why this rating - The public materials show deliberate use of contemplative (Scholé), memorization/recitation, and Socratic-style discussion patterns, with a clear upper-grade rhetoric and presentation emphasis, aligning with CLASSICAL pedagogy. The lower grades emphasize memory and recitation; upper grades emphasize dialogic inquiry and rhetoric.

Cited pointers - Lower-school emphasis on memory and recitation (poetry, narration) and a traditional classroom approach. - Public descriptions of active student participation in discussion and the authority of the teacher in a disciplined environment.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The public materials emphasize teachers who are mentors, capable of modeling virtue and knowledge, with a focus on character formation and the teachers as the living curriculum and core of the school. Visible teacher portraits and faculty pages (including roles, contact, and faculty listings) support this portrayal. - The institution presents a teacher-centered, mentorship-oriented culture in line with classical pedagogy, with a clear emphasis on teacher competence, virtue, and collegiality in the school community. The presence of multiple named faculty and a structured staff directory reinforces the “living curriculum” concept.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: living curriculum, model teachers, mentors, virtue, skill, knowledge, collegial teachers, portrait of teacher/student. - Negative keywords present: None indicating an anti-teacher-led model; no explicit mention of non-teaching staff as a substitute for teachers.

Why this rating - The public materials consistently portray teachers as central, virtuous, and knowledgeable, with explicit references to a teacher-led, mentorship-driven culture that aligns with classical ideals of the faculty as the core of the school.

Cited pointers - Faculty pages and staff listings showing teachers by name and role; statements about teachers as mentors and living curriculum.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The ACANC site actively engages families: tours and information meetings for prospective families, parent meetings, and resources designed to educate parents about the classical model. The school emphasizes parent involvement and collaboration as part of the classical formation process. - The school invites parents to attend visits and participate in school life, with public information meetings and ongoing communications (The Arrow newsletter, parent resources, etc.). This demonstrates a partnership with families consistent with classical education's co-educator model. - Public materials also highlight parent information sessions and the school's emphasis on parent formation and home-school collaboration (e.g., parent meetings, information for new families).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with families, parent involvement, parent education, parent formation, family engagement, school-parent collaboration, tours & information meetings, parent resources. - Negative keywords present: None indicating minimal parental involvement; there is an explicit emphasis on families as partners and co-educators.

Why this rating - The school actively promotes parent engagement and family partnership, consistent with the classical model's emphasis on a collaborative home-school formation and "parents as co-teachers" in the ecosystem of classical education.

Cited pointers - Tours and Information Meetings; parent information sessions; parent resources. - Visit page emphasizing parent education and involvement.

What Would Move the Needle

- Element 1 (Religious and Metaphysical Foundations): Explicitly foreground theology and liturgical/community practices across disciplines. If ACANC were to articulate a clear theological grounding and liturgical dimension within the curriculum (even if ecumenical or broadly religious in orientation, rather than dogmatic), Element 1 would move from SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL to CLASSICAL.
- Rationale: The Positive/Negative keyword framework identifies transcendental realism and virtuous aims as core strengths, but the lack of explicit theological or liturgical statements in public-facing materials is the main gap. Strengthening this would complete the religious-metaphysical axis.

Concrete steps - Add a dedicated statement or framework on theological foundations or liturgical culture within the school's public materials or the explicit integration of theological reflection in core subjects. - Where appropriate, include explicit examples of liturgical or communal practices that connect with virtues (e.g., reflective pauses, ceremonies, or ritual elements tied to virtue formation).

- Element 4 (Pedagogy): Deepen explicit articulation of Socratic seminar models and restorative contemplative elements as regularized pedagogy across grades (even if not named identically in all materials). If the school integrates formalized Socratic seminars at appropriate grade levels and documents these in public materials, Element 4 would reinforce CLASSICAL status.

Concrete steps - Publish a formal Pedagogy Brief that documents Socratic/methodical dialogue across grades, including how memory work, recitation, and rhetoric are used in each stage. - Provide sample lesson structures showing how upper grades deploy Socratic discussions and how lower grades use memory work in a structured, sustainable way.

- Element 5 (Faculty): Expand explicit language and public-facing statements about teachers as “living curriculum” and “portrait of a teacher” with a clearly defined model of teacher virtues and student-mentor relationships. The addition of a public-facing “faculty profile” or “teacher-ethos statement” would strengthen Element 5.

Concrete steps - Publish a formal Faculty Profile or Teacher Ethos document highlighting qualities, professional development, and mentorship roles. - Include testimonials or case studies illustrating how teachers model virtue and craft the culture of the school.

If Element 1 is strengthened along with the minor enhancements above, the school could move from CLASSICAL to an even more robust CLASSICAL across the board.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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